



## PLANTING COCONUT IN SMALL AND URBAN HOME GARDENS

The economy of urban people is severely affected by the price increase of coconut day by day. However, one of two coconut palms could be cultivated even in small home gardens to fulfill the daily coconut requirements. The Coconut Research Institute (CRI) has introduced high yielding coconut hybrids suitable for cultivation in home gardens. It is important to pay attentions to the following details in order to get the best nut production from hybrids palms in home gardens.

### Selection of planting materials

Hybrid planting materials produced by crossing Dwarf x Tall palms which come into bearing at the age of 3 - 4 years giving an annual nut yield of 130- 200 per palm, (CRIC65, Kapruwana, Kapsuwaya, Kapsetha) are the most suitable planting materials for home gardens (figure 1). These hybrid planting materials could be purchased from nurseries managed by CRI or CCB.



*figure 1: Bearing  
CRIC65 palm*

### Selection of planting site

As home gardens have limited space, it is important to select planting site with full sun light by considering the landscaping beauty of the home garden and buildings. If a seedling is planted in a shady place, expected growth and production could not be achieved even with proper application of water and fertilizer. In urban home gardens main problem in coconut cultivation is inadequate sun light availability.

### Method of planting

Please refer the Advisory Circular A3.

## Management practices

After planting, use a mulch to cover the soil around the seedling with coconut fronds, husks or pasture (figure 2). To meet the water requirements of seedlings apply water (10 liters) to each seedling per week. Kitchen waste water could also be used for this purpose.

Seedlings may die suddenly due to deep planting, fungal infection owing to water logging during rain and termite attacks. The most common pests attacking seedlings are Termites, Black Beetle and Plesispa Beetle.

If termite damage is present, drench 5 liters of Marshall 20% mixed with water ( 3-5 ml / 1 liter of water) . However, use of pesticides in home gardens should be minimized.



*figure 2: Correct method of applying a mulch around a coconut seedling*

The Black Beetle penetrates into the tender bud region and feeds on bud tissues. Decayed fiber materials could be seen around the entry hole of the beetle (figure 3). The damage caused by Black Beetle is deformed bud leaves (figure 4), retarded growth of seedlings or even death of seedlings. To control Black Beetle hook out the beetles at regular intervals (figure 5), place 2 - 3 Napthalin balls at leaf axils. Otherwise careful apply used engine oil on leaf bottoms monthly (figure 6). Regularly check the mulch for the presence of Black Beetle grubs. It is also essential to destroy any decaying coconut logs and avoid leaving decaying heaps of organic matter in home gardens (figure 7).

Seedlings are damaged by Plesispa Beetle and larvae feed on the bud leaves resulting in brown patches (figure 8). This damage could be controlled effectively by spraying Marshall 20 SC (4 ml in 1 liter of water) preferably in the early morning at every fortnight until controlled. However, hand picking and destroying pests is environmentally friendly.

For effective growth and early flowing, inorganic fertilizer mixture for young palms (YPM) and Dolomite should be applied in every six months. Otherwise application of only organic manure without chemical fertilizers also brings about proper growth and yield of coconut. Application of organic manures (compost) not only provides plant nutrients and also enhances soil quality.



*figure 3: Tissue debris due to BB damage*



*figure 4: Deformed coconut seedling due to BB damage*



*figure 5: Removing BBs using a metal hook*



*figure 6: Applying pass engine oil on petioles*



*figure 7: Breeding of BB lavas on decaying materials*



*figure 8: Plessispa Beetle damage on coconut seedling*

## **Recommended doses for application of YPM mixture and Dolomite**

Please refer the Advisory Circular A5.

Fertilizer application should be carried out when the soil is moist. Fertilizer mixture should be broadcast around the seedling 3 feet away from the base and incorporated with the soil. If the seedlings are provided with proper nutrients, water and sunlight hybrid plants come into bearing in 3-4 years of age. If you can have such bearing palms which fulfill your day to day coconut requirements it not only provides financial benefits but also mental satisfaction.

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